

02

Finding Your Angle

Document 2 of 9

If you're new to this series, start with ****What a Headline Actually Does****.

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What Is an Angle?

An angle is the **big idea** your ad leads with — the specific doorway through which the reader enters your story. It is not the product, it is not the benefit, and it is **not a headline**. The same product with the same benefit can be introduced through a dozen different doorways, and which doorway you pick usually matters more than any wordsmithing you do afterward.

All marketing is storytelling, and a funnel tells one story: the ad is the beginning, the advertorial or jump page is the middle, and the offer's sales page or VSL is the end. The angle is how all the elements of the ad work together to *start* that story. Get the angle right and everything downstream gets easier — the click is qualified, the middle page has a narrative to continue, the close feels inevitable. Get it wrong and no amount of headline polish will save you: you're polishing a doorway to a room the reader never wanted to enter.

This is why experienced media buyers say the magic isn't in the image, the platform, or the bid strategy. The magic is in the angle.

Keep the order of operations straight: angles come first, headlines come second. An angle is a decision about *which story to start*; a headline is one of many possible sentences that starts it. You will always identify your angles before you write a single headline — and every angle you pick should eventually get several competing headlines, not one. This document teaches the first step. Documents 1, 7, and 8 teach the second.

There Is No Master List of Angles

Before we name any categories, get one thing straight: **angles are countless**. An angle lives at the intersection of a product, a specific reader, and a specific moment — what they've already tried, what they're afraid of, who they think they are. Products are many, readers are many, moments are endless; multiply those together and you get an unbounded space of doorways. Nobody has catalogued them all, because they can't be catalogued. New winning angles show up in the ad feeds every single month that fit no list anyone wrote down.

That's not a problem — it's the opportunity. If angles were a fixed menu, every advertiser would order the same dishes and the reader would have seen them all. Your edge as a media buyer comes precisely from finding the doorway the last ten advertisers *didn't* use. This document teaches you **how to think about angles** — how to generate them, hold them, and choose between them — not a set of boxes to put them in.

You will meet named families of angles below, and they're genuinely useful. But hold them the right way: they're the doorways that have recurred often enough to earn names, the way "mystery" and "romance" are shelves in a bookstore. The shelves help you browse. They don't limit what can be written.

Writing an Angle Down: The Angle Statement

Because an angle is an idea and not a sentence of copy, you need a way to hold it that doesn't sneak into headline-writing. Use an **angle statement**: one plain line naming the doorway, written with no craft at all.

Warning angle: your current fix is quietly failing and you don't know it.

Story angle: an ordinary insider refused to live with the problem and built his own solution.

Discovery angle: researchers found the real biological reason the problem persists.

An angle statement is deliberately unglamorous. If it reads like an ad, you've skipped ahead. The test: a good angle statement could produce ten different headlines; a headline can only produce itself.

Brainstorming the Nugget: "What Do People With Feet, Do?"

Before you can pick an angle, you need raw material — the small, concrete, everyday truths about your audience that an angle can hook into. There's a wonderfully silly brainstorming question from the angle-hunting tradition that captures the method:

"What do people with feet, do?"

They walk. They stand all day at work. They get sore heels. They buy shoes that wear out. They kick off those shoes with a sigh at 6 p.m. They notice cold floors in winter. Every one of those humdrum behaviors is a potential hook, because every one of them is a moment your reader actually lives.

The question generalizes: whatever your product touches, ask *what do people with [that thing] actually do all day?* People with lawns mow, water, glare at brown patches, and silently compete with the neighbor. People with power bills open the envelope wincing. People with desk jobs shift in their chairs every twenty minutes. Angles built on observed behavior land as recognition — "that's me" — which is the strongest possible opening note for cold traffic. Angles built on marketing abstractions ("optimize your comfort!") land as advertising, and get filtered out.

And don't stop at imagining your audience — *read* them. The reviews of the offer you're promoting, the comments under its ads, the forum threads about the problem: that's your audience describing their own moments, in their own phrasing. Don't guess what people with feet do when you can read a hundred of them saying it.

Collect these nuggets before writing anything. The best angle is usually sitting inside the most ordinary behavior on your list. And notice what this exercise proves: the angles come from the *audience's life*, not from any list of categories — which is exactly why no list of categories can contain them all.

The Three Questions Every Angle Must Answer

So where do angles come from? Anywhere. A gold line in the advertorial (Document 3 is the full workflow for that). A nugget from your audience's day. A phrase from a one-star review. A competitor's ad in a spy tool. A thought in the shower. The source of an angle doesn't matter — and any teaching that says angles can only come from one place is selling you a fence.

What matters is that **every angle, wherever it came from, must answer three questions** before it goes anywhere near traffic. Picture three overlapping circles — *what this reader will feel, what the page can pay off, what the reader hasn't already seen*. A viable angle lives where all three overlap. The questions are how you check:

Question 1 — Who exactly is this doorway for? Not a demographic — a person.

"Women over 40" is not an answer; *a woman in her fifties who has quietly stopped trusting her doctor's advice about her knees* is an answer. If you're marketing to everyone, you're marketing to no one — and an angle that can't name its one specific reader isn't an angle yet; it's a slogan looking for a victim. Every angle statement you write should be written *for someone*, and you should be able to say who.

Question 2 — What on the page pays it off? You're an affiliate: the advertorial and sales page are fixed, and whatever doorway your ad opens, *those pages* must deliver on it. This is congruence, and it's broader than any single line. The test is whether the page pays off the **sentiment** of the angle — the promise the doorway makes — and pays it off *proportionally*. In plain terms: the page must deliver the feeling and promise the doorway creates, in roughly the amount the doorway suggests. **Mention is not payoff.** If your angle leads with saving money and the page spends one throwaway sentence on cost before four paragraphs of inventor story, the reader feels baited, no matter what the page technically "contains." The bigger the promise of the doorway, the more of the page must be spent delivering on it. So for every angle — extracted, invented, or borrowed — you must be able to *point at the part of the page that pays it off*. If you can't point at anything, the angle is wrong for this offer, no matter how good it is.

Question 3 — Why hasn't this reader already walked past it? Your reader scrolls past hundreds of ads a week, and the doorways run by every other affiliate on the offer are already invisible to them. This is where spy tools — tools that show you the ads competitors are running — and your own feed research earn their keep: they show you which angles are **saturated**, meaning already used so often that this reader scrolls right past them. An angle can name its reader and be fully paid off by the page and *still* be dead — because the reader has seen that exact doorway forty times this month. Fresh doesn't mean exotic; it means *this reader hasn't been approached through this door lately*. (One caution when a spy tool hands you a competitor's angle: it was built to be paid off by *their* page — run it through Question 2 against yours before you borrow it.)

Three questions, and they're quick — usually well under a minute per angle once you have the habit. They're not a workflow — they're a filter that every workflow's output goes through. Document 3 teaches the most reliable *generator* of angles — mining the page itself, which hands you angles already anchored to what the page can pay off; the questions are how you check everything, from every source.

Recurring Angle Families: A Gallery, Not a Fence

Certain doorways recur so often in winning ads that they've earned names. Learn them as **lenses**: point each one at your product and see what it shows you. What follows is a gallery of the families you'll meet most often in native and advertorial traffic — not a complete inventory, because no complete inventory exists.

Story. A named or relatable person's transformation, told as narrative. *An ordinary person discovers a path and gets a result.* Story angles work because humans are wired to finish narratives, and because a story lowers the reader's guard — the claim doesn't arrive as an advertiser's promise; the reader watches it happen to a person. They aren't being promised anything; they're just hearing what happened to someone else.

Warning. Lead with a mistake, a hidden danger, or a loss to avoid. *The thing you trust is failing you, and here are the signs.* We fear losing more than we love gaining, and a warning frames the click as protective, not indulgent. Warning angles also read as public-service content, which suits editorial placements.

Discovery / News. Frame the product's mechanism as a new finding. *Something new changes how this problem gets handled.* Newness answers "why am I only hearing about this now?" and gives the reader permission to hope again after past failures — *this one is different because it's new.*

Contrarian. Attack the conventional wisdom. *Everything you've been told about this is backwards.* Contrarian angles create instant tension with what the reader believes, and they flatter the reader as someone smart enough to hear the real story. They also *justify past failure* — "the standard advice was the problem, not you" — which unlocks readers who've given up.

Local. Anchor the story in the reader's own geography. *People right here are quietly switching.* Local angles make the story feel like community news rather than an ad — which only works when the local claim is true and the page supports it — and they sharpen relevance: the story didn't happen to someone in the abstract; it happened *here*. (Modern ad platforms can insert the reader's region dynamically, which is why this family thrives in native feeds.)

Unique Mechanism. Lead with the how itself: the named method, ingredient, or process (see **Curiosity: Withholding the How**). *There's a specific mechanism behind this, and it has a name.* Best when your audience has already tried the obvious solutions — the mechanism *is* the news.

Transformation. Lead with the outcome itself, made vivid and specific — the before-and-after as the doorway. *This result is achievable, and here's what it looks like.* Transformation angles dominate fitness, beauty, and finance because the reader can picture themselves on the far side. The risk is believability: a transformation angle leans hard on proof (see **Believability and Proof**).

Social Proof / Authority. Lead with who already trusts this: the crowd (*thousands are quietly switching*) or the expert (*a specialist finally explains what actually works*). These angles let someone else make the claim so the reader doesn't have to take the advertiser's word for it.

You'll also see other named doorways in the wild — **comparison** angles (*we tested five so you don't have to*, common in listicle-style pages) and **identity** angles (*made for people like us*) among them. They're further proof that the gallery has no back wall.

And you'll sometimes lead with a **benefit lead** — a nugget so strong it can open the ad on its own (*this costs less than the habit it replaces*). A benefit lead is a legitimate doorway too: it belongs to **Selling the Benefit, Not the Product**, and it competes with your other angles in testing like any doorway does.

Three honest notes about this gallery:

- **The families combine freely.** *A local everywoman stumbles across a discovery is* Local + Story + Discovery in a single angle. Stacking is normal, not cheating.
- **Different teachers group angles differently.** Some work with four broad lenses, some with eight or more. None of these lists is official, because there's nothing to be official about — they're all just different ways of shelving the same unbounded space.
- **An angle that fits no family is not a mistake.** If you've found a doorway that answers the three questions and it doesn't wear any of the names above, run it. Unclassifiable might mean *unfenced* — and unfenced might be your edge.

Matching the Angle to Audience Awareness

Which doorway should you lead with? The biggest input is your reader's **stage of awareness** — how much they already know about their problem and its solutions. This is Question 1 sharpened: not just *who* the reader is, but *what state of mind they're in* when your ad interrupts them.

- **Unaware / problem-unaware readers** don't yet feel the problem sharply. Warning and Story angles work best: a warning surfaces a pain they hadn't named; a story lets them recognize themselves in someone else before any pitch begins.
- **Problem-aware readers** know the pain but not the solutions. Discovery/News angles shine here — they've been waiting for exactly this headline: *there's finally something for this*. Vivid Transformation angles also work: they've felt the before; show them the after.
- **Solution-aware readers** know the category and have probably tried things that failed. Unique Mechanism and Contrarian angles win: the mechanism explains why this attempt will end differently, and the contrarian frame explains why the previous ones didn't.
- **Product-aware and skeptical readers** respond to proof-heavy Story, Social Proof, and Local angles — specific people, specific places, specific numbers (see **Believability and Proof**).

One workable way to run the selection — not the only way, just a reliable starting method: gather your raw material, note your reader's dominant awareness stage, shortlist a few doorways that fit that stage — named family or not — and write an angle statement for each. Two or three is a sensible starting range, not a rule; run the doorways your reader's state of mind actually calls for. You can just as legitimately start from the page (Document 3), from audience research, or from a passage arc that grabbed you. **The families are lenses for generating and naming angles, never a checklist to test through.** Nobody runs one of each. The families are cheap to try on paper — the expensive mistake is committing your whole funnel to the first angle you thought of.

One Product, Three Angles

Take a fictional home water filter, the ClearSpring. Same product, same core benefit — three different doorways, held as angle statements:

Warning angle: the filter you already own is quietly missing what matters, and you've never been shown the evidence.

Story angle: a retired tradesman who'd seen the problem from the inside refused to accept it at home — so he built his own fix.

Local angle: households in the reader's own region are quietly changing how they drink their water.

Each doorway would attract a different reader in a different state of mind, hand a different story to the middle page, and produce different economics — and you cannot know which wins from your desk. That's what testing is for. The craft is generating genuinely *different* doorways, not three rewordings of one idea — and each of the three still has to answer the three questions before it spends a dollar.

Notice that none of these are headlines yet. Each angle statement could yield five or ten competing headlines when you get to Documents 1, 7, and 8 — and headline examples built on angles like these are collected in **Headline Formulas and the Swipe File**.

■ Calibrating the Angle Across the Three Surfaces

An angle is not just an ad trick — it's the one idea that runs through the whole funnel, and each surface plays a different part of it.

- **Ad — angle discovery.** The reader *meets* the angle: the warning is raised, the story begins, the discovery is announced. The ad's only job is to make this doorway irresistible to walk through.
- **Advertorial — angle proof.** The middle page backs up the angle the ad opened: the warning gets evidence, the story gets its full arc, the mechanism gets its explanation. Changing angles mid-funnel — clicking a warning and landing on an unrelated cheerful story — breaks the scent, and readers leave feeling misled. This is Question 2 playing out in real time: the page either pays the doorway off, or the reader is gone.

- **Jump page — angle sharpened into the watch.** On this route the reader meets the angle at the ad and lands here one click later. The jump page gives the angle just enough immediate support to make pressing play feel credible — the video then delivers the full proof. The jump page's job is to convert the angle into a plain reason to press play: the danger now avoidable, the transformation now available, the discovery now watchable.

One angle running the whole route — the same underlying idea, adapted to each surface's job — never different angles taped together.

Where to Go From Here

You now know what an angle is, how to hold one as an angle statement, and the three questions every angle must answer. Two paths continue from this point:

- **Extracting angles from existing copy** — most of the time you're promoting an offer that already has an advertorial and a sales page, and the strongest angle material is often already inside them. **Document 3: Extracting Angles from Existing Copy** teaches the line-by-line mining workflow — the most reliable generator of angles, because its output arrives already anchored to the page — including how to run it with an AI assistant and check the machine's work.
- **Turning angles into headlines** — once your angle list is set, write several competing headlines *per angle* using **What a Headline Actually Does**, **Headline Formulas and the Swipe File**, and **Word Choice: Context and Power**.

Keep the wall between the two steps. Deciding which story to start and writing the sentence that starts it are different skills, done at different times.

✓ Key Takeaways

- The angle is the big idea your ad leads with — the doorway into the story. It matters more than wordsmithing, and it is **not a headline**.
- **Angles are countless.** They live at the intersection of product, reader, and moment — no list contains them all, and your edge is often the doorway no list

named.

- Angles first, headlines second — always. Hold angles as plain **angle statements**; if it reads like an ad, you've skipped ahead.
- Angles can come from anywhere — the page, the audience's life, the customers' own words, the spy tools. What matters is the **three questions** every angle must answer: *Who exactly is this for? What on the page pays it off? Why hasn't this reader already walked past it?*
- **Congruence is about sentiment, paid off proportionally — mention is not payoff.** If you can't point at the part of the page that delivers the doorway's promise, it's the wrong angle for this offer.
- If you're marketing to everyone, you're marketing to no one: every angle statement is written for one specific reader you can describe.
- Learn the recurring families — **Story, Warning, Discovery/News, Contrarian, Local, Unique Mechanism, Transformation, Social Proof/Authority**, plus the honest **benefit lead** — as a gallery of lenses, not a fence. They combine freely, other traditions group them differently, and an angle that fits no family may be your best one.
- Match the doorway to the reader's awareness stage — and never treat the families as a checklist to test through.
- Generate genuinely different doorways before testing; three rewordings of one idea is not a test.
- The angle runs the whole funnel: discovered at the ad, proven through the advertorial, or carried by the jump page into the video.